

COLOUR KEY: Keyboard Slash cmd Workflow Skill/agent CLI/flag Config/env ★ New in 2026 Removed/deprecated

Getting the Most Out of Claude Code

A practical guide and reference — verified July 16 2026 against CLI v2.1.211 · Compiled by Douglas Mun

Claude Code is an agentic coding assistant — it reads your repo, runs commands, edits files, and manages git workflows within the permission boundaries you set. The gap between casual and expert use is narrow but compounds: practitioners plan before they build, give Claude durable project memory, isolate risky work in worktrees, and offload repeated thinking to skills, plugins, and subagents.

Entries in section colour are stable. ★ marks features new in 2026 (v2.1.160+). Struck-through entries are removed/deprecated. Start non-trivial work in plan mode (Shift+Tab or /plan). Put durable context in CLAUDE.md. Raise effort with /effort xhigh on Opus 4.8. Install an LSP plugin so Claude sees type errors live.

SESSION & CONTEXT

`/clear` Clear history — aliases: /reset, /new
`/compact [instr]` Compact conv. with optional focus
`/context` Visualise context usage as a grid
`/copy [N]` Copy last (or Nth) response
`/diff` Interactive diff — uncommitted + per-turn
`/export [file]` Export conversation as plain text
`/rewind` Rewind conv/code (alias: /checkpoint)
`/branch [name]` Branch conversation (alias: /fork)
`/resume [session]` Resume by ID/name (alias: /continue)
`/rename [name]` Rename session; shows on prompt bar
`/recap ★` Show session context recap
`/btw <question>` Side question — no context cost

Model & Effort

`/model [model]` Pick/change model; ←→ adjusts effort
`/effort [level]` low/med/high/xhigh★/max/auto
`/fast [on|off]` Toggle fast mode

Display & Config

`/config` Open settings (alias: /settings)
`/theme ★` Change theme — custom themes
`/color [color]` Set prompt-bar colour for session
`/tui [fullscreen] ★` Flicker-free fullscreen render
`/focus ★` Toggle focus view
`/statusline ★` Configure shell prompt status line
`/keybindings` Open/create keybindings config
`/terminal-setup` Configure Shift+Enter shortcut
`/permissions` Manage allow/ask/deny rules
`/status` Settings — version, model, network

TOOLS & INTEGRATION

`/init` Initialize project CLAUDE.md
`/memory` Edit CLAUDE.md; manage auto-memory
`/mcp` Manage MCP server connections
`/hooks` View hook configurations
`/skills` List skills — t sorts by tokens
`/agents` Agents view (Setup wizard removed)
`/plugin [list] ★` Plugin mgr; list --enabled/--disabled
`/chrome` Configure Claude in Chrome
`/cd <path> ★` Change session working directory
`/dataviz ★` Chart + dashboard design skill
`/add-dir <path>` Add working directory
`/install-github-app ★` Set up Claude GitHub Actions
`/install-slack-app ★` Install Claude Slack app (OAuth)
`/web-setup ★` Connect GitHub to Code on web

Workflows & Agentic

`/plan [desc]` Enter plan mode with optional task
`/batch <instr>` 5–30 worktree agents [Skill]
`/simplify [focus]` 3-agent parallel review [Skill]
`/debug [desc]` Debug logging + analysis [Skill]
`/loop [interval]` Recurring task; self-paces [Skill]
`/workflows ★` Deterministic multi-agent orchestration
`/schedule [desc] ★` Create/run routines
`/ultraplan <prompt> ★` Cloud plan editor → web UI
`/code-review ultra ★` Cloud multi-agent review
`/autofix-pr [prompt] ★` Web agent auto-fix PR CI
`/security-review ★` Scan branch diff for vulns
`/team-onboarding ★` Replayable guide from history
`/claude-api` Load API reference [Skill]

Remote & Sessions

`/remote-control` Enable remote control (alias: /rc)
`/teleport /tp ★` Pull web session → terminal
`/remote-env ★` Configure default remote env
`/voice` Toggle push-to-talk dictation
`/desktop /app` Continue in Desktop app
`/mobile /ios` QR code for Claude mobile app
`/sandbox ★` Toggle sandbox mode
`/tasks ★` List bg tasks (alias: /bashes)

UTILITY

`/usage ★` Plan limits + rate status
`/usage-credits ★` Request more credits from admin
`/stats` Opens /usage → Stats tab
`/cost` Opens /usage → Cost tab
`/extra-usage` Keep working past rate limits
`/insights` Report on patterns + friction
`/doctor /checkup` Full setup checkup; f = auto-fix
`/powerup ★` Interactive tutorials + demos
`/release-notes` Changelog — version picker
`/feedback /bug` Submit feedback
`/help` Show help and commands
`/exit /quit` Exit the CLI
`/login /logout` Sign in / out

Removed / Deprecated

~~/pr-comments~~ Removed v2.1.91 — ask Claude
~~/vim~~ Removed v2.1.92 — /config → Editor
~~/review~~ Deprecated — code-review plugin
~~/tag~~ Removed in v2.1.92
~~/ultra-review~~ Deprecated → /code-review ultra
~~/agents-wizard~~ Setup wizard removed v2.1.198

★ QUICK TIPS

Type /s to see every command filtered live
Skills (bundled or user-made) share the same UI as built-in commands
Some commands are platform-dependent
Plugin commands are namespaced:
/`<plugin-name>`;`<command>`

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GENERAL CONTROLS

MODE & NAVIGATION

VIM EDITOR MODE

Ctrl+C Cancel input / generation
Ctrl+D Exit session (EOF)
Ctrl+L Clear prompt + force redraw
Ctrl+O Toggle transcript viewer
Ctrl+R Reverse search history
Ctrl+G Open prompt in editor
Ctrl+B Background task (tmux: twice)
Ctrl+T Toggle task list
Ctrl+V Paste image → [Image #N]
Esc Esc Rewind / summarize
↑ ↓ Cursor / history navigation

Text Editing

Ctrl+A Start of current line
Ctrl+E End of current line
Ctrl+K Delete to end of line
Ctrl+U Delete to start of line
Ctrl+W Delete previous word
Ctrl+Y Paste deleted text (yank)
Alt+B / Alt+F Back / forward one word ■

Multiline Input

\+Enter Universal — any terminal
Ctrl+J Universal control seq
Shift+Enter iTerm2/WezTerm/Ghostty/Kitty
Option+Enter macOS Option-as-Meta

Permission & Model Modes

Shift+Tab Cycle permission modes
Alt+M Cycle modes (alt)
Option+P / Alt+P Switch model
Option+T / Alt+T Toggle thinking
Option+O / Alt+O Toggle fast mode

Transcript Viewer (Ctrl+O)

Ctrl+E Toggle show all content
/ Search transcript
n / N Next / previous match
[Dump to scrollbar
v Open in \$VISUAL/\$EDITOR
q Exit transcript

Voice Dictation

Space Hold or tap to dictate
/voice Tap → push-to-talk mode

Enable: /config → Editor mode

Esc NORMAL mode
i / a Insert before / after
h j k l Move left/down/up/right
w e b Word next/end/prev
0 \$ ^ Line start / end / non-blank
gg G Top / bottom of input
x dd D Del char / line / to end
yy p Yank / paste
u . Undo / repeat

■ macOS OPTION-AS-META SETUP

Alt+B, Alt+F, Alt+M, Alt+P, Alt+T need
Option configured as Meta:
iTerm2: Profiles → Keys → Left Option = Esc+
Terminal.app: check “Use Option as Meta Key”
VS Code: terminal.integrated.macOptionIsMeta:true

Beyond the Cheat Sheet — Tips to Save Tokens and Work Smarter

1. Know where tokens go. Every turn sends the full conversation, active tool schemas, loaded CLAUDE.md, and system prompt. Run /context to see the breakdown; check /usage after expensive ops. Find the single biggest offender rather than micro-optimising.
2. Plan before you spend. Enter plan mode for anything non-trivial — Claude researches and proposes in one pass. Use /compact focus on <topic> proactively. Put durable facts in CLAUDE.md so they survive compaction.
3. Match model & effort. Opus 4.8 at xhigh is extraordinary for complex agentic coding; routine edits run fine on Sonnet 5 (default, 1M context) at medium. Subscription users get a 1-hour cache TTL automatically.
4. Delegate — don't clutter. Spawn the Explore subagent (read-only, inherits session model capped at Opus). Subagents now run in the background by default. Use /btw for side questions. For parallel work, launch --worktree sessions.

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CLI COMMANDS	CONFIG & ENV VARIABLES	PERMISSION MODES & HOOKS
claude Start interactive session claude "query" Session with initial prompt claude -p "query" Headless / print mode claude -c Continue most recent conv. claude -r "name" Resume by name or ID claude update Update to latest version claude install [ver] ★ Install specific / stable claude auth login ★ Sign in (--console for API) claude auth status ★ Auth status (--text = human) claude agents ★ List configured subagents claude setup-token ★ Long-lived token for CI claude remote-control ★ Start remote-control server claude mcp Configure MCP servers claude plugin ★ Manage plugins	Authentication ANTHROPIC_API_KEY API key (overrides sub) CLAUDE_CODE_OAUTH_TOKEN Long-lived OAuth for CI ANTHROPIC_AUTH_TOKEN Custom Authorization header ANTHROPIC_BASE_URL Proxy / gateway endpoint Providers CLAUDE_CODE_USE_BEDROCK Use AWS Bedrock CLAUDE_CODE_USE_VERTEX Use Google Vertex AI CLAUDE_CODE_USE_FOUNDRY ★ Use Microsoft Foundry CLAUDE_CODE_USE_MANTLE ★ Use Bedrock Mantle AWS_BEARER_TOKEN_BEDROCK Bedrock API key Behaviour & Features DISABLE_AUTOUPDATER Disable auto-updates DISABLE_UPDATES ★ Block ALL updates CLAUDE_CODE_ENABLE_AUTO_MODE ★ Opt into auto mode (BR/VX) CLAUDE_CODE_EXPERIMENTAL_AGENT_TEAMS ★ Enable agent teams (=1) CLAUDE_CODE_DISABLE_1M_CONTEXT ★ Block 1M context models CLAUDE_CODE_DISABLE_MOUSE_CLICKS ★ Disable mouse clicks CLAUDE_CODE_DISABLE_ALTERNATE_SCREEN ★ Inline — no fullscreen CLAUDE_CODE_RETRY_WATCHDOG ★ Raise retry on stalls CLAUDE_CODE_FORWARD_SUBAGENT_TEXT ★ Subagent text in stream-json CLAUDE_CODE_SAFE_MODE ★ Start w/ customizations off CLAUDE_CODE_PROCESS_WRAPPER ★ Corporate launcher wrap CLAUDE_CLIENT_PRESENCE_FILE ★ Client presence marker MAX_THINKING_TOKENS Thinking budget (0=off) MAX_MCP_OUTPUT_TOKENS MCP tool response cap CLAUDE_CODE_MAX_RETRIES API retry count (cap 15) ENABLE_PROMPT_CACHING_1H ★ Request 1-hour cache TTL CLAUDE_CONFIG_DIR Override config directory CLAUDE_ENV_FILE Sourced before each Bash cmd	Permission Modes (Shift+Tab) default Prompt on risky — "Manual" in UI acceptEdits Auto-allow edits; prompt on Bash plan Read-only research / planning auto ★ Classifier allows safe / denies risky dontAsk Deny silently, no prompt bypassPermissions Skip ALL checks (dangerous) Hook Events (lifecycle) SessionStart Session begins or resumes SessionEnd Session terminates PostSession ★ After session — self-hosted runners UserPromptSubmit Before prompt processed UserPromptExpansion ★ Before user cmd → prompt PreToolUse Before tool call (can block) PostToolUse After tool call succeeds PostToolUseFailure ★ After tool call fails PostToolBatch ★ After parallel batch resolves PermissionRequest Permission dialog appears PermissionDenied ★ Auto-mode denial (can retry) SubagentStart ★ Subagent spawned SubagentStop ★ Finishes — can add context TaskCreated ★ Via TaskCreate TaskCompleted ★ Task marked complete Stop ★ Finishes — can add context StopFailure ★ Turn ended on API error PreCompact ★ Before context compaction PostCompact ★ After compaction completes Notification Claude sends notification CwdChanged ★ Working directory changes FileChanged ★ Watched file changes on disk InstructionsLoaded ★ CLAUDE.md / rules loaded

Key CLI Flags

--model sonnet / opus / full name

--permission-mode default/acceptEdits/plan/auto★/bypass

--effort low/med/high/xhigh★/max

--output-format text / json / stream-json

--max-turns N Limit agentic turns

--max-budget-usd N Cost cap per session

--worktree / -w ★ Isolated git worktree

--tmux ★ Create tmux pane for worktree

--bare ★ Faster startup — skip plugins

--agent <name> ★ Specify agent for session

--agents {JSON} ★ Define agents dynamically

--from-pr N ★ Resume PR-linked sessions

--fork-session ★ New ID when resuming

--name / -n "x" ★ Set session display name

--remote "task" Create web session

--teleport ★ Pull web → local terminal

--mcp-config <file> ★ Load MCP from JSON

--settings <file> ★ Load extra settings

--json-schema {...} ★ Validated JSON output

--forward-subagent-text ★ Subagent text/thinking in stream

--safe-mode ★ Start w/ all customizations off

--dangerously-skip-permissions Bypass ALL checks

--verbose Full turn-by-turn logs

--version / -v Show version

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CODE INTELLIGENCE (LSP)	OFFICIAL PLUGINS	PLUGIN MANAGEMENT
Install binary FIRST, then plugin <code>typescript-lsp</code> TS / JavaScript <code>pyright-lsp</code> Python <code>rust-analyzer-lsp</code> Rust <code>gopls-lsp</code> Go <code>clangd-lsp</code> C / C++ <code>csharp-lsp</code> C# <code>jdts-lsp</code> Java <code>kotlin-lsp</code> Kotlin <code>swift-lsp</code> Swift <code>lua-lsp</code> Lua <code>php-lsp</code> PHP What Claude Gains <code>Auto diagnostics</code> Errors after every edit <code>Go to definition</code> Jump across files <code>Find references</code> All usages of a symbol <code>Hover types</code> Type info without compiling	Marketplace: <code>claude-plugins-official</code> <code>github</code> PRs, issues, repos, Actions <code>gitlab</code> MRs, issues, pipelines Project / Design <code>atlassian</code> Jira + Confluence <code>asana</code> Tasks via Asana MCP <code>linear</code> Issues, cycles <code>notion</code> Pages, databases, search Infra / Comms <code>figma</code> Files, components, designs <code>vercel</code> Deploy, inspect projects <code>firebase</code> Firestore, Auth, Hosting <code>supabase</code> Postgres, Auth, Edge Fns <code>slack</code> Post messages, read channels <code>sentry</code> Errors, issues, replays Dev Workflows <code>commit-commands</code> Git commit/push/PR <code>pr-review-toolkit</code> PR review agents <code>code-review</code> Replaces deprecated <code>/review</code> <code>agent-sdk-dev</code> Build w/ Agent SDK <code>plugin-dev</code> Create & debug plugins	CLI Commands <code>claude plugin install <n></code> Install from marketplace <code>claude plugin uninstall <n></code> Remove (–keep-data) <code>claude plugin enable/disable</code> Toggle plugin <code>claude plugin update <n></code> Update to latest <code>claude plugin list</code> List installed (–json) <code>claude plugin validate</code> Check schemas Plugin Path Variables <code>\${CLAUDE_PLUGIN_ROOT}</code> Install dir (changes on update) <code>\${CLAUDE_PLUGIN_DATA}</code> Persistent — survives updates <code>\${user_config.KEY}</code> User-supplied config value ★ A+ TIPS <code>/reload-plugins</code> after install = no restart <code>--plugin-dir <path></code> loads local plugins <code>claude plugin validate</code> catches schema errors <code>\$(CLAUDE_PLUGIN_DATA)</code> survives updates <code>Ctrl+O</code> shows LSP diagnostics indicator

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MODEL GUIDE

Models (Jul 2026)

Opus 4.8 Top model — complex agentic coding
Sonnet 5 Default · 1M-token context
Haiku 4.5 Fast, cheap — light tasks
Fable 5 ★ Mythos-class model

Effort Levels

low Renames, mechanical edits
medium Routine coding, lookups
high Multi-file changes
xhigh ★ ★ Hard agentic problems (Opus 4.8)
max Deepest reasoning

★ WHAT CHANGED IN v2.0

Sonnet 5 default · Opus 4.8 top · Fable 5
"default" mode now labeled Manual (2.1.200)
Subagents run background by default; nest
up to 5 levels; auto-commit/push/PR
/workflows — deterministic orchestration
/ultrareview → /code-review ultra
/agents setup wizard removed (2.1.198)

QUICK WINS

--bare Skip plugins/hooks (fast start)
--max-budget-usd N Cap headless runs
Grep/Glob Prefer over Read for discovery
MAX_THINKING_TOKENS=0 When thinking doesn't help
/clear After a break vs re-caching stale
/skills t Sort by tokens — prune heavy

★ TOKEN DISCIPLINE

Every turn re-sends full conversation +
tool schemas + CLAUDE.md + system prompt
/context finds the biggest offender fast
/btw reuses parent cache, skips history
Prefer @path/to/file over pasting contents
Avoid switching models mid-conversation —
next turn re-reads history uncached

CONFIG FILES

~/.claude/settings.json User (global)
.claude/settings.json Project (via git)
.claude/settings.local.json Local (gitignored)
~/.claude/CLAUDE.md Global personal memory
CLAUDE.md (root) Project memory (survives
compact)
.claude/rules/*.md Rule fragments by path

New Settings Keys

fallbackModel ★ Up to 3 fallback models
disableBundledSkills ★ Turn off bundled skills
wheelScrollAcceleration... ★ Mouse-wheel accel
toggle
Tool(param:value) ★ Permission rule by tool input

★ EXPERT HABITS

Plan before you build — /plan for anything
touching more than a couple files
Durable facts → CLAUDE.md, not chat
Codify repeated workflows as skills
Isolate risky work in --worktree sessions
Install an LSP plugin for live type errors